phosphoric acid', for $38 million or Rs 166 crore, along with its two existing JV partners. The company also 'entered into two separate agreements' to acquire a majority stake in the UK-based chemical company the Brunner Mond Group. It was one of the world's largest manufacturers and suppliers of sodium bicarbonate and soda ash. First, Tata Chemicals acquired a majority stake (63.5 per cent) in Brunner Mond.

The following year, it bought the remaining 36.5 per cent stake. The acquisition was important as it gave Tata Chemicals ownership of the Magadi plant in Kenya and access to markets in Europe, Africa and Asia. It elevated Tata Chemicals to the third-largest soda ash manufacturer in the world and doubled its 'annual production of soda ash to more than two million tonne'. The acquisition also gave it all the 'big customers in Europe' and some of the best European markets, comments Menon. It broke the virtual control of the foreign companies that were exporting soda ash to India, which served a critical national goal, he adds. This was very important as at that time, the US companies had formed a cartel to sell and export soda ash, influencing the international cost of the product.

The decision to acquire the soda ash plant was also strategic. In the fifteen years it has been under Tata, the plant has been able to record a 17.6 per cent CAGR. Further, as Subodh Srivastav, the MD of the company, states, when the African continent breaks out into a higher growth trajectory, which would be sooner than later, Tata Magadi would be an important partner in the growth with the demand of soda ash rising as an important component in the production of glass and detergents. He adds that from a sustainability angle, the acquisition brought 'tremendous value to the group'.

The soda ash produced at Magadi 'was the cheapest at the gate', comments Mike Odera. With the middle class growing, the demand for products requiring soda ash for their production is bound to increase, and it made the acquisition of the company a strategic move, he adds, echoing the same views as Srivastav.

The acquisition also revealed another dimension of Ratan's personality—his concern for the welfare of the workers and the community that became evident long before he held any substantial position in the group. The Magadi chemical plant also witnessed the implementation of Ratan's vision through welfare activities for the workers, their families and the community living in its vicinity.